Lesson Plan: Political Contexts and Digital Ecosystems

Description of the lesson

This lesson provides a deep dive into the profound transformation of political, social, and civic life in the age of digital platforms. It explores how modern society has become "extremely online," affecting all generations, and introduces the concept of "brain rot" (the 2024 Oxford Word of the Year) to describe minds overwhelmed by algorithmic content.

The lesson traces the evolution of digital spaces from the text-based networks of 2010 to the video-dominated landscape of 2025, positioning this shift as a return to an "oral culture" where social videos are the new storytelling campfires.

Participants will critically examine how physical political spaces (like the youth culture, social centers and squats of the 80s and 90s) have been replaced by digital spaces like Discord, Twitch, Reddit, and Fortnite.

Through analysis, the lesson tackles the dangers of "technofeudalism" (platforms acting as modern feudal estates) and "clicktivism/slacktivism." It uncovers the hidden mechanics of radicalization—showing how memes act as "Trojan horses" for ideology and how the Overton window is shifted through irony and "shitposting."

Finally, the lesson deconstructs the algorithmic "attention economy" (rooted in Facebook's 2009 introduction of the algorithmic feed as humanity's digital "original sin") and equips participants with the psychological and technical strategies of effective video activism.

Learning objectives

By the end of the lesson, participants will be able to:

- Identify the mechanisms of the "attention economy" and how algorithms shape political reality;
- Analyze how humor and "shitposting" act as vehicles for ideological radicalization;
- Understand the shift from physical to digital political spaces (Discord, Twitch, TikTok, etc.);
- Evaluate the effectiveness and risks of "clicktivism" versus tangible political action;
- Apply the principles of successful video activism (the 3-second rule, metrics, and emotional hooks) responsibly.

Target group

Young people interested in media literacy, digital sociology, and activism, particularly those active in the digital space who wish to understand the underlying mechanics of the content they consume and create.

Duration

Approximately 90 minutes.

Learning outcomes, content, teaching and learning methods, and evaluation methods

Learning outcomes	**Content**	**Teaching and learning methods**	**Evaluation methods**
Explain the impact of the digital attention economy	Attention economy, algorithms as "black boxes," the role of "brain rot"	Short lecture; visual analysis of social media feeds	Class discussion; reflection
Identify ideological tools in digital media	Memes as "Trojan horses," shitposting, shifting the Overton Window	Guided analysis of case studies (memes/videos)	Worksheet on ideological messaging
Evaluate digital activism strategies	Click-tivism vs. real-world impact; video activism; psychological triggers	Case study of successful vs. failed digital campaigns	Group presentation; peer feedback

Lesson structure

1. Introduction: Digital Daily Life (10 minutes)

- Discussion on the term "brain rot" and the transition from text-based to video-saturated environments.
- Question: How has your consumption of information changed over the last few years?

2. Input: The Political Digital Ecosystem (20 minutes)

- **The Attention Economy:** Algorithmic influence since 2009.
- **New Political Spaces:** Discord, Twitch, and Reddit as the new "town squares."
- **Ideological Funnels:** How memes act as "Trojan horses" for radicalization and shift the Overton Window.

3. Workshop: The Anatomy of a Viral Message (30 minutes)

- Analysis of successful video activism.
- Focus on: The "3-second rule," pacing, and emotional triggers (laughter, anger, belonging).
- Case study: Why do we share what we share? (Identity building vs. community belonging).

4. Group Activity: Dissecting Digital Influence (20 minutes)

- Groups analyze a current viral video or political meme.
- They must identify: The intended emotion, the hidden message (if any), and how the algorithm likely boosted this content.

5. Reflection and closing (10 minutes)

- Closing questions: How can we remain critical in a digital-feudal ecosystem? Can we use these platforms for good without falling into "slacktivism"?
- Final takeaway: Participants share one strategy to be more mindful of algorithmic influence.

Materials for teaching

Material	**Form**
Political Contexts and Digital Ecosystems	Presentation
Selection of current TikTok/Reels political content.	Case studies
"Anatomy of an Algorithmic Post" (template for deconstruction).	Worksheet
Laptop, projector and internet connection, and personal devices for quick research	Technical equipment

Evaluation of the lesson

Evaluation is carried out through active participation in the group analysis, the quality of the insights in the worksheets, and a final oral reflection on media responsibility.